



Pace cover: India head coach Gautam Gambhir trusts India's fast-bowling depth to handle Jasprit Bumrah's possible absence from a few games. AFP

themselves, they have taken the ownership and responsibility, they've realised it's going to be a tough tour. That's the pleasing thing for us as coaches, to see guys taking that leadership and ownership at practice," India's bowling coach Morne Morkel said, adding: "England - the brand of cricket they play, we need to be on top of our game. We can't afford to find our feet in this series." The coaching staff is optimistic, but performances will need to match that belief — especially in Bumrah's absence.

The venue spread adds another layer of complexity:

India has never won at Edgbaston (7 losses, 1 draw).

At Lord's, it's three wins in 19 Tests.

Old Trafford has been tough: four losses, five draws.

At The Oval, India has won twice — the last time in 2021.

"The bowling unit looks settled, but then, some of them have not much experience in Test cricket, so it might not be easy to claim 20 wickets in every game, and it will be important

to identify that bowler who would anchor the bowling department whenever Bumrah isn't around," former India fast bowler Ghavri said.

Conditions vary, too. Lord's has a 2.5-metre slope from one side to the other, which can significantly influence swing and seam. At The Oval, spin comes into play.

"In conditions where the ball swings and seams, you cannot be erratic. And it's important to be consistent in bowling in the right areas," Ghavri said.

Kuldeep Yadav or Washington Sundar could be surprise options at The Oval alongside Jadeja. But for the bowlers to have an impact, the batters need to put up scores.

"Our bowlers can get those wickets, but before that, we also need to put up at least 400 odd runs. Now, the question remains, who's going to do it?" Ghavri wondered.

India has scored 400+ just twice in its last eight Tests — once against New Zealand, once in Perth.

And this time, there's no safety net of experience.



India's records in England since 1932 (by venue)

HEADINGLEY

Matches: 6

England: 3

India: 2

Drawn: 1

EDGBASTON

Matches: 8

England: 7

India: 0

Drawn: 1

LORD'S

Matches: 19

England: 12

India: 3

Drawn: 4

OLD TRAFFORD

Matches: 9

England: 4

India: 0

Drawn: 5

THE OVAL

Matches: 15*

England: 5

India: 2

Drawn: 7

*India also played the WTC final here against Australia in 2023, where it lost

**India has also played three Tests at Rose Bowl in Southampton (two against England in 2014 and 2018 and against New Zealand in the final of the WTC in 2021) and lost all three.

"Shubman has the temperament, but it needs to be seen whether he can hang in there and score those runs. Most of these players are very comfortable in T20 cricket, so it's not easy to switch formats. In such a crucial tour, Shubman, Rahul, (Yashasvi) Jaiswal and Sai Sudharsan need to step up and steady the batting order."

On paper, the squad has talent. But it must win critical moments. That, more than match-ups or averages, will define this tour.

The TV promo is bold: "Sikhne nahi, seekhane aaye hain..."

Now they'll need to prove it — not just with intent, but with execution.